

RUSSIAN FEDERATION

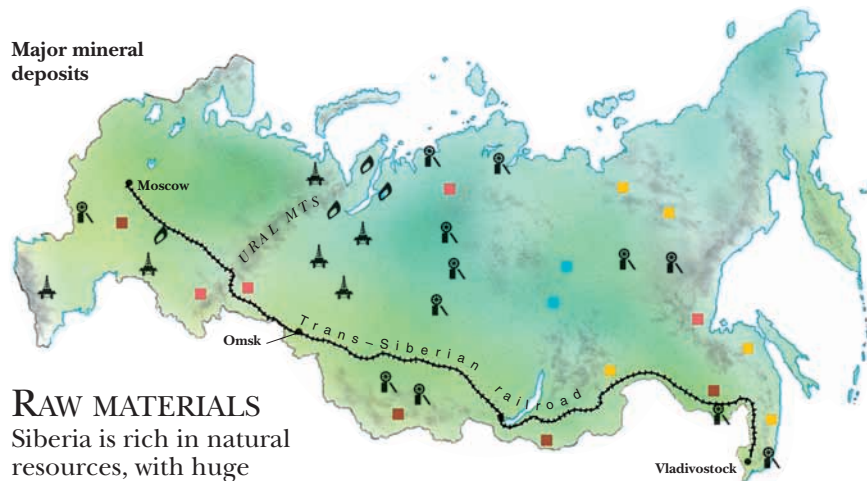
TO THE EAST of the Ural Mountains lies Asian Russia. This vast expanse of land, known as Siberia, is bigger than the combined size of the US and western Europe. Yet because of the harsh climate, only 40 million people live here. Parts of Siberia are colder in winter than the North Pole. To the north are frozen plains, or tundra, while farther south it is just warm enough to grow some hardy crops. For centuries, Siberia remained undeveloped, home only to peoples who trapped animals for their meat and fur and caught fish in the local rivers. But the discovery of minerals, such as gold and diamonds, has opened the region up to economic and industrial development.



KAMCHATKA

Hanging off the eastern end of Siberia, the Kamchatka Peninsula is one of the most isolated parts of Russia. Under the Soviet Union, Kamchatka bristled with military bases because of its closeness to both Japan and the US. Today, the military presence is reduced and people are returning to more traditional ways of making a living. Once more, people are fishing in the many rivers, herding reindeer, or hunting seals, sea otters, and bears for their skins.

Major mineral deposits



RAW MATERIALS

Siberia is rich in natural resources, with huge reserves of oil, gas, coal, metals, diamonds, and gold. The Trans-Siberian railroad transports vast amounts of minerals from Siberia to European Russia. Western Siberia contains one-third of the world's natural gas reserves, as well as a huge oilfield producing 8.4 million barrels of oil a day, more than two-thirds of the entire Russian output. Development of these resources, however, is difficult, for the climate is harsh and laying pipelines to carry fuel over such long distances is expensive.



The elegant dining car of the Trans-Siberian Express

THE TRANS-SIBERIAN RAILROAD

The Trans-Siberian railroad is the world's longest continuous rail line. It begins at Moscow's Yaroslavl station in the west and stretches 5,866 miles (9,440 km) across to Vladivostok in the east. Trains cross eight time zones and take eight days to complete the journey. In recent years the line has become increasingly congested. New lines, including the Baikal-Amur Mainline, have been built alongside to relieve this problem.

The boxes are often decorated with scenes from fairy tales.



ARTS AND CRAFTS

The rise in Russian nationalism has been accompanied by a return to traditional crafts, folk tales, and music and dance. Skilled craftworkers make boxes and other items from wood or *papier mâché*. The lacquered boxes are decorated with miniature paintings.



CLOSED AND SECRET CITIES

Under Soviet Union rule, two types of cities were off limits to all but an authorized few. Closed cities, including Vladivostok (shown left), were sites of military or industrial importance. Secret cities were places of research in chemical and nuclear warfare. They did not appear on maps and were located in remote areas surrounded by restricted-access zones, patrolled by armed guards. Today, most closed cities are open to visitors, but secret cities remain out of bounds.